



metroPLUS



Chennai's chess culture is turning a city park into a space for learning and community **P3**

WHAT'S HAPPENING ON THE SETS OF MADDY? **P4**

Lassi

Imagine lassi in its most traditional setting and you picture a burly farmer in Punjab, readying himself for the day's work. What was once a regional staple has now become a national favourite, cutting across geographies to emerge as a beloved drink for all seasons, especially as a summer cooler.

One of Chennai's more famous lassis found its way to the hot, humid Madras of nearly four decades ago thanks to Dinesh Soni, a wrestler from Pushkar. Though born into a family of goldsmiths, Dinesh chose a different path – one that led him to Sowcarpet, the bustling commercial hub of George Town. There, amid the chaos of Mint Street, he set up Anmol Mohit Soni Pattiyala, today widely known as Anmol Lassi. The menu is simple: kesar lassi and masala buttermilk, both crowd favourites.

Operating from 7am to 8pm, the stall sits at a street corner near Kakada Ramprasad. "We've been here since 1989," says Mohit. The lassi is thick, creamy and speckled with tiny bits of kova, delicately flavoured with kesar – best enjoyed cold, in a steel tumbler, and often followed by another. It is priced at ₹220 for 750ml, while half a tumbler is priced at ₹110. The masala buttermilk is priced at ₹60.

Other places serving lassi include: Ajnabi's original outlet at Fountain Plaza and Bombay Lassi on Ellis Road (at the exit gate of Devi Paradise) in Triplicane, which gives you a topping of malai with a sprinkling of sugar for ₹55.



A MURALITHARAN

Nannari sharbath

There is nothing quite like a tall glass of nannari sharbath to quench your thirst. It can be easily made at home using the nannari concentrate sold in bottles. The sharbath has to be mixed with water and tastes best when had cold.

Nannari sharbath is made from the roots of the sarsaparilla. It is a popular summer drink known for reducing body heat, featuring a sweet, earthy, and tangy flavour, often mixed with water or soda, lime, and sometimes basil seeds.

Chennai has two popular brands: 777 and Mambalam Iyers. Mambalam Iyers nannari sharbath is sold in 700ml and 750ml bottles. The 777 nannari sharbath is priced at ₹130 for a 700ml bottle. Both are available in most departmental stores and provision shops across the city.



Kulfi

Kulfi is a classic frozen dessert, often likened to ice cream but distinct in both preparation and texture. It is made by slowly reducing sweetened, flavoured milk until it thickens into a rich, concentrated base.

This is then poured into moulds and frozen. Kulfi is not aerated, resulting in a dense, creamy texture that melts slowly and delivers an intense, lingering flavour.

Kulfi remains a quintessential summer cooler – a traditional way to beat the heat. Though many ice cream brands and parlours offer their own versions, Bombay Kulfi stands apart with outlets for this dessert.

The brand was conceived by Manish Kankaria from Coimbatore, with its manufacturing base in Mumbai. In Chennai, it is represented by franchisee Hitesh Khanna, who introduced the brand to the city in 2016 with outlets in Anna Nagar, Vepery and Adyar.

Bombay Kulfi uses A2 cow's milk, lending a distinctive richness to its products.

The range includes around 35 flavours available in sticks, slices and takeaway pots. There is also an ice cream line with 12 flavours, including seasonal favourites such as alphonso mango.

Among its highlights is the Rangeela kulfi – a colourful four-in-one stick that combines pista, chocolate, malai and butterscotch – a playful twist on a traditional favourite.

The sticks are priced at ₹75, slices at ₹95 and the pots at ₹95.



Summer, interrupted

It is that time of year when Chennai turns to its thirst-quenchers.

We go on a chill trail across the city, and bring you our favourite atypical summer coolers

Nikhil Raghavan

Thandai

Traditionally associated with Holi – and setting aside the more indulgent bhang-laced versions – thandai is a classic North Indian beverage, made with milk, poppy seeds, fennel, black pepper, saffron, dried fruits and almonds. It is valued for its cooling and restorative properties.

In Chennai, Govindam has been instrumental in introducing thandai to a wider audience. Located at Rottler Lane in Vepery, this café-cum-store was set up two years ago by entrepreneur



Govind Mundra. Govindam has brought a distinctive slice of North Indian dessert culture to the city, with thandai emerging as one of its signature offerings.

The menu features three variants – kesar thandai, paan thandai and coconut thandai. The kesar version highlights the rich aroma of saffron, while the paan incorporates betel leaves, lending it a unique, refreshing note.

Behind the modest

storefront lies Govindam's own manufacturing facility, where ingredients are handpicked and processed in a hygienic environment. The brand also produces shrikhand, lassi and mishti doi.

Prepared in stainless steel equipment using a time-tested recipe personally supervised by Govind, the thandai is packed in convenient flip-top cans, making it easy to chill and ensuring freshness. Extending its reach, Govindam caters to customers across the city through food delivery platforms and a retail van that serves neighbourhoods, events and functions.

Kesar thandai is priced at ₹80, the paan variant costs ₹90 for a can.



PHOTOS: R RAVINDRAN

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For centuries, the female form has captivated artists across generations – from Leonardo da Vinci's Mona Lisa to Johannes Vermeer's Girl with a Pearl Earring and Sandro Botticelli's The Birth of Venus.

In India, too, this fascination endures, from Raja Ravi Varma to Amrita Sher-Gil, where female portraiture has long remained central to artistic discourse.

At Ashvita's in Chennai, that dialogue continues through the works of the late artist SK Rajavelu. Titled The Body, As Is, the exhibition explores the human form through precise, unbroken contours.

Executed primarily through ink on paper, many works depict reclining female figures, their curves perhaps shaped by the artist's travels to Thanjavur, Kumbakonam, and Lepakshi, alongside the long hours he spent at the Government Museum in



Shifting bodies Everyday female figures by SK Rajavelu (below). ASHVITA'S AND RAMA SURESH M



Egmore, to study sculptures and murals. "The nude was historically connected to tantric symbolism or celestial forms like yakshis and apsaras in Indian art, but colonial rule, Victorian morality, and Western academic art had an impact on how nudity was shown, criticised, and embraced in

contemporary India," says curator Rithik Pramod.

In 1965, a national scholarship brought him to Baroda, where he trained under NS Bendre. During this time, his interactions with artists like KG Subramanyan led to deeper interactions with India's visual traditions.

"While many artists of the 1960s and 70s turned towards bold colour or abstraction, Rajavelu remained committed to the human figure. His drawings do not frame the nude as spectacle or provocation; instead, they approach the body as a structure through which line, rhythm, and balance are explored," adds Rithik.

Mostly untitled, the works on view are intimate ink drawings that foreground everyday female figures rendered through searching strokes. In one, a mother and child can be seen embracing each other; in another, clustered figurines of women appear; and in some,

male figurines also make an appearance. "Today, we are used to fast images and quick viewing. These drawings ask us to slow down and really look," says Rithik.

Associated with the Madras Art Movement, Rajavelu was part of a dynamic circle in the city, including HV Ramgopal, Anthony Doss, AP Santhanaraj, and L Munuswamy, all of whom had a deep influence on him over the years.

He also worked as Deputy Director at the Weavers' Service Centre in Vijayawada, where his close engagement with craft traditions shaped his visual language.

Rajavelu passed away in Chennai in 2015, leaving behind a body of work that captures his enduring legacy, which might perhaps spark a larger conversation on drawing the female form in India.

The Body, As Is, is on at Ashvita's, Dr Radhakrishnan Salai till May 22, from 11am to 7pm. Entry is free

STEP OUT



Journeys drawn

Artist Srikanth Sivaraj's debut solo, My Lines and My Witness: A Journey through Light, Lands and Life, presents hundreds of works spanning portraits, landscapes, and travel impressions. Created in graphite, coloured pencils, pastels, and ink, the show reflects his journeys across India and countries such as Vietnam, Bangladesh, and Morocco, shaped by years of practise and rediscovery. On view till April 27, 11am to 7pm, at Lalit Kala Akademi, Grems Road. Entry is free.



Chennai tastes Tuscany

Head to East Coast at Madras Square, ECR, for an intimate sit-down dinner. This weekend, Chef Ralph D'souza, is working with Chef Aarnav

Merchant to host The Tuscan Experience, a seven-course Italian dinner with dishes like cold pea soup, lamb tortelloni, eggplant parmesan, 10-layer lasagna and more. The experience costs ₹2,000 per person. For reservations, log on to @madrassquare on Instagram.



Life in symmetry Interiors of the different mansions and palaces of Chettinad; (inset) an Athangudi tile being made. THE HINDU ARCHIVES AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Learn the stories of formidable Chettiar women, textile trade ties between India and South-East Asia, and tuck into the softest kola urundais at The Chettinad Heritage and Cultural Festival between September 18 and 21

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Five editions ago, when the conversation surrounding the Chettinad Heritage and Cultural Festival first began, the approvals were frankly straightforward. “Yacob George [late general manager, The Bangla, a heritage guesthouse in Karaikudi] asked if we could do it, and I said yes,” says the founder and owner of The Bangala, Meenakshi Meyyappan.

Leela Samson curated the first edition with around 70-80 guests. “We knew that she was the person for the job. She chartered out the whole programme and that is how the first edition went,” says Mrs Meyyappan. Over the years, the festival which takes people through a nuanced understanding of the Nattukottai Chettiars, their traditions and customs, became bigger. There were tours of

century-old mansions with symmetric Burma teak pillars and lit by Belgian chandeliers and Italian marble flooring. These were built, mostly in the 19th Century by the mercantile Chettiar community, who travelled and worked all over South-East Asia, according to an article in *The Hindu*.

Since then, the annual festival has seen a number of prominent

personalities partaking in cultural performances, enlightening conversations, and tucking into sumptuous food from the Chettinad region, all while gaining a deep understanding of this independent microcosm which is the Nagarathar community.

This year, the festival returns between September 18 and 21, tickets for which are now available. During this edition, one can

partake in a conversation with politician and author Shashii Tharoor, listen to music performances by the likes of Uthara Unnikrishnan and Usha Venkatraman, watch dance renditions about classical games, and take in discussions about the formidable women of Chettinad, the reality of the mansions in the region, and understand the trade ties between India and South-East Asia from the lens of this community. This is besides visits to several houses, and temples in the region spread across 76 villages in the Sivaganga and Pudukkottai district, and a view of how the perfectly congruent Athangudi tiles are made.

Mrs Meyyappan, now 90, says that the festival is less about Chettiars, and more about a comprehensive understanding of Tamil Nadu as a State. Over the last few years, planning for the festival has begun in December, especially in order to confirm the speakers for



the event. “I’ve started a trust where the members and I, sit down to finalise the itinerary,” she says. Over the years, volunteers have helped execute these programmes. However, this time, an event management company is involved, Mrs Meyyappan adds.

What can one most look forward to at the festival? Mrs Meyyappan has her list ready. “While I’m interested in many parts of this festival, I’m excited to hear Mr Tharoor speak. I hope he talks

about colonial India. I’m also eager to hear researcher Peter Lee and designer Ashdeen talk about trade ties between India and South-East Asia. Ahalya Mathan’s registry of sari exhibition is also interesting. There’s going to be a talk about the formidable aachi, and one about houses too, that I would like to hear,” she says.

Food has become a talking point each year. Think perfectly shaped, soft mutton kola urundais, and a delicious spread of seasonal vegetables on a fresh banana leaf. Mrs Meyyappan, an expert on food herself, says that there is a perception that Chettinad food is often spicy. “That is never the case. I just bought 500 kilograms of gundu molaga from Ramanathapuram which is then deseeded and used. It is hardly spicy but is flavourful. We want to break the perception that the food from here makes your eyes water, and instead have people enjoy the subtle flavours of this region’s cuisine,” she says.

No better time to learn about a region than total immersion.

To book your place, write to chettinadheritagefestival@gmail.com

Lineage in craft

At Anvaya, India’s craft traditions unfold through mythology, material, and master artisans

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In a country where stories were once told not in ink but in thread, carved in wood, and painted in pigment, craft has always been more than just an ornament. Anvaya, a curated exhibition of India’s living craft traditions, arrives in Chennai this week, bringing together historic art, textiles, and material practices.

Presented by Aabharnam Foundation, a New Delhi-based initiative with a longstanding legacy in India’s textile ecosystem, the three-day exhibition unfolds at The Folly, Amethyst. Curated by textile collector and cultural practitioner Neha Verma, Anvaya brings together the works of 18 master artisans across disciplines.

“This is not a bazaar, but a curated design show. Every artist’s work is



Legacy in thread A
Benaras sari. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

exclusive, not something you can find very easily,” says Neha, positioning Anvaya as an experience that moves away from conventional craft markets and towards a more deliberate, design-led showcase. The emphasis here is on rarity and on slowing the act of viewing,

and recognising the labour, time, and inherited knowledge embedded in each piece.

The exhibition is expected to bring together a range of regional practices that engage with mythology. According to the organisers, this includes Odisha’s

pattachitra, where narratives from the *Ramayana* and Krishna lore are depicted using natural pigments, alongside West Bengal’s kantha embroidery, which works with layers of repurposed fabric. Pichwai paintings from Rajasthan, kalalamkari from Andhra Pradesh, and sanjhi art from Uttar Pradesh offer a distinct interpretation of myth through craft.

Anvaya also foregrounds the people behind them. The exhibition is rooted in a model that works directly with artisan communities, with a significant portion of proceeds routed back to the makers.

For curator Neha Verma, Chennai was a deliberate starting point for the travelling exhibition. “I always wanted to create that space and platform in cities where people have an understanding of traditional craft, where they value tradition, and truly understand the craft,” she says, adding that the exhibition will travel to Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and Pune next.

Anvaya is on at *The Folly, Amethyst* from April 28 to 30, 11am to 8pm.



Riders on the storm

Con Anthony Conlon on training, tackling and completing the toughest footrace on Earth

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Con Anthony Conlon has always been fascinated by the stories of the explorers and adventurers of yore: Ferdinand Magellan, Vasco da Gama, James Cook, Ernest Shackleton, George Mallory, “the usual suspects,” says the Chennai-based entrepreneur.

It is part of the reason he decided to embark on the Marathon des Sables, a legendary ultramarathon through the Moroccan Sahara, often called the toughest footrace on Earth. “It was a little bit of wanting to see what that kind of experience would be like, even in a very small way,” says the 54-year-old Irishman, who has just returned from the gruelling week-long race, held between April 5-11 this year.

Con was already “kind of a runner” who had regularly participated in some 10km

runs, half marathons, and full marathons. However, the Marathon des Sables, founded by the French explorer Patrick Bauer in 1986, is an intimidating run for even the most seasoned athletes; over 250 kilometres across scorching sand, with participants carrying all their food and essentials on their backs.

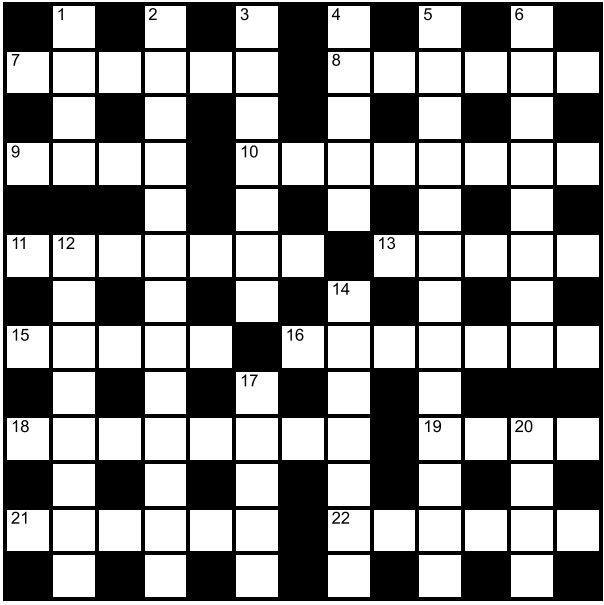
Unsurprisingly, it took him nearly a year to train for the race, which involved pounding nearly 90 kilometres of pavement every week, along with three days of strength training. “I would do 15 kilometres four times a week, and then on weekends, either on Saturday or Sunday, a 30- to 40-kilometre run,” he says.

By December 2025, he stepped up his training and started running with an eight-kilogram backpack, says Con, whose training in Chennai elicited amusement among many passersby. “I would run up and down Greenways Road with my backpack in the middle of the day. I think I may

be a topic of some humour in the tea shops in that part of town,” he grins. The weight of this backpack, made this already “very tough race”, even harder. “It increased the nature of the challenge, and you have to factor that in.” Con goes on to explain the format of the Marathon des Sables, which is broken up into daily stages. “The first day had, for instance, 35 kilometres, the second stage had 40 kilometres, and the third stage was 29 kilometres,” he says. Then came what is called “the long day”, during which nearly 100 kilometres were covered, followed by a rest day. “Then, we have a rest day before stage five, a full marathon – 42 kilometres, while the last day was about 23 kilometres,” he says, adding that he personally, had found the first two days difficult since he was recovering from a bout of food poisoning. “By the time I arrived at the race, I was completely depleted, so I was a bit unlucky with that.” Another challenge was the six-hour sandstorm Con encountered on the fifth day of the run. “It was like something out of a Mad Max movie,” he says, with a laugh. But he also has fond memories of the experience: camels racing alongside the runners, beautiful sunsets, the extraordinary landscape, and inspiring people he met along the way. “There were people of much smaller stature, from Hong Kong or Japan, carrying huge backpacks and making it to the finish line. It was really impressive,” says Con, the only person from India who participated in the race this year. “But there have definitely been Indian competitors in the past, and hopefully we may see more in the years to come. It is a great event.”

A marathoner’s mirage Con and other runners at the Marathon des Sables, a legendary ultramarathon. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

QUICK CROSSWORD #50 (Set by Doppelganger)



Across

- 7 Disfigure (6)
- 8 Closed meeting (6)
- 9 Gramophone record (4)
- 10 Area far from cricket pitch (8)
- 11 Food provider at event (7)
- 13 Luminous (5)
- 15 The heavens (5)
- 16 Stronghold (7)
- 18 Prepare for use (8)
- 19 Suspend movement (4)
- 21 Repository of interesting objects (6)
- 22 Act of letting out (6)

Down

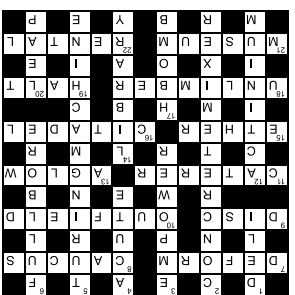
- 1 Food shop (4)
- 2 Construction equipment (8,5)
- 3 Authorise (7)
- 4 Keenly perceptive (5)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



- 5 Hypothetical computing device (6,7)
- 6 Thoroughgoing (4-4)
- 12 Radioactive element (8)
- 14 Literary collection (7)
- 17 Nuclear weapon (1-4)
- 20 Jump (4)

Solution No. 50



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Last week, one of the most exciting stories in the sports pages of the newspaper was Grandmaster R Vaishali's triumph at the Candidates Tournament in Pegeia, Cyprus, on April 15. The Chennai-based chess player became the first Indian woman to win this prestigious event which was established in 1952. With this landmark victory, Vaishali is now set to become only the second Indian woman to compete in the World Championship – an accomplishment that is no mean feat.

Would it be a stretch to say that the city she is from has played an integral role in her life? Not really, considering that of the 83 grandmasters in India, 29 are from Tamil Nadu. From this subset, it is reported that 15 are from one Chennai school, Velammal Vidyalaya in Mogappair – Vaishali's alma mater.

Not too far away from this institution is Anna Nagar Tower Park. At this location, on the steps along the park's little lake, are at least 50 strangers sharing 25 chess boards, moving their rooks, knights, pawns, and queens, with easy focus and concentration. These are friendly matches, after all. On a few boards though, friends cosplaying arch rivals, play each other with deft ruthlessness. A war is afoot.

The sight alone is inviting, communicating to strangers that any free board is ready for play.

Your move
Over three years, Chennai Chess Club's chess at the park initiative has helped build friendships, let strangers unwind, and has allowed for a deeper understanding of chess moves, all whilst taking in Anna

Over 64 squares

Inside Chennai's intellectual third space where friends and strangers kill rooks, knights, and queens over a board



Nagar's legato-esque breeze. Once a month, in the third week, the park transforms into an intellectual third space akin to places like Washington Square Park, Moscow, Lima, and Bandra's Carter Road where chess is played in public, and the games are open to all.

"We began Chennai Chess Club just as the pandemic blockade was lifting back in March 2023. Although there was a chess-craze during the COVID lockdown, the sport was played in isolation on sites like Chess.Com and lichess.com. Using Reddit, Twitter,

Instagram and WhatsApp, we decided to spread the word and ask people to come and play over-the-board chess. We thought that it would be a good idea to explore the social side of the sport," says Paul Vannan K, one of the two founders of this chess club. Varun K, the other founder, says that they first organised meet-ups at cafes every Sunday. "Our first meeting had 12 people. The participants have been growing ever since," he says. One of Chennai Chess Club's most heartening results is the fact that there are volunteers who oversee the games at the park. "Everyone joined out of curiosity and a need to play the game. Now, we are all friends," says Paul.

Sudarshan R, a class XI student and the son of a chess coach, says that he is most delighted to learn in an atmosphere that is easy-going. "The air at a chess tournament is full of tension. It is serious. There is little to no space for conversation, making it a difficult space to learn. Here though, one can finish a game and analyse the board. Those who win, teach. Those who lose, learn," he says.

Varun, who has been playing chess since he was in Class III, says that Chennai's chess scene has transformed dramatically. Back when he was playing, people would travel for a few tournaments across the State. Today, there is more than one

Queen's sacrifice An open chess meetup by Chennai Chess Club draws players to Anna Nagar.

B VELANKANNI RAJ

competitive event every week. "Online forums have made it remarkably easy to learn chess. All one needs is practice. This too has led to a rise in the number of chess players in Chennai," he says.

All of these causes are besides the obvious influences who exist in the State including Viswanathan Anand, Gukesh Dommaraju, and R Praggnanandhaa. "They seem like they could be our neighbours. Knowing that makes chess an easy dream to pursue," Paul says. Paul says that there is a definite Goofy Gen effect on young, new players who are taking to the sport in Tamil Nadu. "He [Instagram influencer Suthershun Asokan] is a fantastic player. Many before him have made chess content. Yet, he has found a fantastic way to reach the non-chess crowd, causing a great rise in an interest," he says. Those who are experienced players also find some solace from their routines at the park. Swetha R who is back on the steps after a year's maternity break, says that for one and a half years, life was all-consuming. "Through it all though, chess has remained consistent. I learnt to play from my grandfather when I was young. It keeps me connected to him too. Something about sitting in front of the board," she says, trailing off.

Has she observed a change in the gender gap in the last three years? "In the beginning, there weren't many women, but there has been a slow rise in the last few years," she says. As the sun sets, the pieces killed off the board are laid back neatly in the bags. The green and white chess boards are rolled up and packed. Today's quota of 64 squares is done. Until next month.

For details, follow @chennaichessclub on Instagram. Entry is free.

India in focus

Jina Park takes us through an immersive journey across the country, camera in hand

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When Jina Park first arrived in India, she felt she had stepped into an entirely different world. "Everything fascinated me – the sound, the colours, the people, the kindness," she recalls. That sense of wonder led her on an immersive journey across the country, from the ghats of Benaras to the mountains of Ladakh, and the deserts of Rajasthan, the bustling lanes of Mumbai, and through Tamil Nadu, where she now lives. These experiences came together in her debut solo exhibition in Chennai, Lyrical Encounter: India through a Korean Lens.

Born and raised in Seoul, the capital of South Korea, travel has shaped much of her life, influenced by her expat husband. It was only after moving to India and spending two years here that she began pursuing photography professionally.

In Benaras, the smiling sadhus becomes the main character. "Before I went to Varanasi, I thought of sadhus as mythical and out

of reach. And yes, they are deeply spiritual. But what surprised me was how disarmingly human they are," says Jina.

During a visit to the Bonda, Dongria Kondh, and Gadaba tribes in Odisha, she created a striking series of portraits of tribal women, an experience she describes as a "chance encounter." "Because our encounter was spontaneous, they weren't dressed up for the camera – this is how they present themselves in their everyday lives."

In Mumbai, Jina's exploration took her to the lanes of Dharavi, photographing the socio-economic contrast of the city. "What I like most in India is the people. They are friendly, curious, and open to being photographed," says Jina.

"There are moments that can be difficult to witness, but I find myself constantly grateful for the kindness and for the unique beauty that exists here," says Jina.

On at Shakuntala Art Gallery, CP Ramaswami Aiyar Foundation, till April 26. Entry is free.



Frozen in time
A sadhu photographed in Benaras. JINA PARK

Brewed and cultured

Chennai-based cheesemaker Käse collaborates with roastery and café Beachville for a limited-time pop-up



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Wine and cheese may sit comfortably at the top of the pairing pyramid, but there is a more nuanced conversation brewing between coffee and cheese.

Käse, a Chennai-based cheesemaker, is collaborating with the city's roastery and café Beachville for a limited-time pop-up that brings artisanal cheese and specialty coffee onto the same table. The pop-up is structured as an evolving menu that changes every 10 days, unfolding across three chapters of small plates.

"Anything that has acidity, body and sweetness can be paired. Cheese has it. Coffee has it," says Divya Jayshankar of Beachville. Instead of a one-off event, the experience is folded into

the café, allowing people to walk in and engage with it at their own pace.

The pairings follow a clear logic. Higher-acidity cheeses meet brighter, lighter roasts, while aged, heavier cheeses like parmesan and pecorino are matched with darker roasts that hold their own. The aim is to ensure neither the coffee nor the cheese flattens the other. "Instead of asking people to sign up and come for an event, we wanted to make it easier to access," she says.

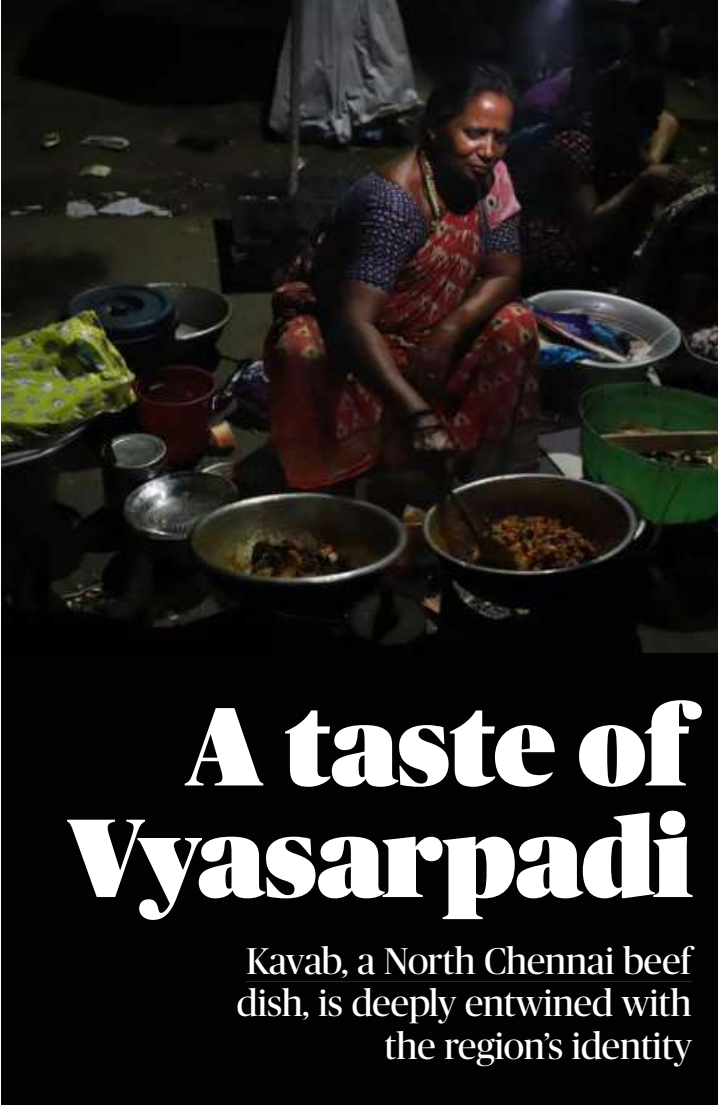
A crisp spanakopita, with flaky layers and a savoury feta cheese filling, is paired with a pour-over that carries notes of caramel and berry.

Cheesy cups (Left) Mexican street-corn and pan seared halloumi with coffee pairings; (below) foccacia flat bread. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The kimchi toast with cheddar cheese curds is offset by a cold brew with hints of dark chocolate and jasmine. The Mexican street corn, esquites, brings together sweet corn and cotija cheese, is paired with an Americano. Grilled halloumi, finished with hot honey, is paired with a cortado, the milk and espresso cutting through its salt and spice.

Dessert follows a similar line: a Basque cheesecake matched with a deeper, chocolate-toned pour-over and the Russian cottage cheese pancakes, syrniki, topped with a blueberry compote, are paired with an espresso with notes of caramel, honey and mango.

Käse x Beachville is on at Beachville Coffee Roasters, Alwarpet from April 24 until the end of May. Each pairing costs ₹600.



A taste of Vyasarpadi

Kavab, a North Chennai beef dish, is deeply entwined with the region's identity

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Anthony Amma is seated in a street corner surrounded by large cauldrons of simmering meat curries. She stirs the dishes intermittently as customers surround her like bees ordering a little of this and a little of that, that she swiftly packs in neat paper parcels. It is almost 9pm – peak dinner time at Vysarpadi's JJR Nagar's 5th Street – and men, women, and children come in droves to buy beef offal curries to be had with rice back home. The dishes, collectively known as kavab, are

a North Chennai speciality, one that is deeply entwined with the region's culture and identity.

"I grew up eating kavab," says N Sakthivel from Vyasai Thozhargal, a movement that empowers children through education. The 31-year-old recalls how the dish, which consists of meat cut into small cubes and cooked until tender with a crisp exterior, was a popular after-school, pre-dinner snack in his younger years. "Women would sell it on the streets. For as little as ₹5, they would serve a handful that we would munch on as we ran to play football," says the documentary photographer. Sakthivel points out how the

A cultural hotspot Vendors making kavab, a beef offal curry from Vyasarpadi.

N SAKTHIVEL AND AKHILA EASWARAN



dish was popularised by being featured in the lyrics on The Casteless Collective's 'Beef Song'. However, it remains confined to the borders of North Chennai. Kavab, a portion of which is priced at ₹10, is easy on the pocket and is filling too. "Which is why men who work physically demanding jobs prefer a few servings of it for dinner. It satiates large appetites."

A Vijaya has been selling kavab for 18 years at JJ Nagar. "I buy the meat from a slaughterhouse in Aaduthotti at 8am," says the 60-year-old, adding: "I wash it several times after which I boil it for over three hours," she explains. Once cooked well, she sprinkles salt and chilli powder and lets the mixture marinate.

Every time there is sambar or kara kozhambu at home, I come here straight. Kavab makes any kozhambu bearable.

S GOVINDAN
Auto driver

Vijaya sets up her stall at around 8pm to coincide with the time when the region's loadmen and auto-drivers come back home from work. The roasting begins at the stall – she cooks the meat in its own fat and juices, stirring it in a wide-mouthed pan on the stove.

These days though, the number of women making the dish has reduced owing to the sheer process of preparing the meat. "A number of Chinese fast-food and chicken pakoda shops have sprung up in North Chennai, that many people now prefer over kavab," says Sakthivel.

At Anthony Amma's stall meanwhile, crowds surge as the clock inches closer to 10pm. She has been selling for 35 years and is one of the most popular kavab sellers in the region. S Keerthana, a college student, has come to buy some for dinner and S Govindan, an auto driver, has rice back home that he will pair with meat. "Every time there is sambar or kara kozhambu at home, I come here straight," he chuckles. "Kavab makes any kozhambu bearable."



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The punishing Chennai sun burns bright above the heads of a dozen workers who are erecting a grand wedding set on the lawn of a beachside resort in ECR, Chennai. Assistant directors, production assistants, and other technicians have turned the resort into a hive of activity. This is the high-octane environment I enter as I step into the sets of *Maddy*, the upcoming Tamil film starring Rio Raj and Saniya Iyappan.

Produced by Kalai Arasu's Roll Time Studios and directed by Karthikeyan BK, an erstwhile assistant of Lokesh Kanagaraj and Hip Hop Tamizha, *Maddy* is a rom-com that tells the cat-and-mouse cricket-love story of a CSK fan and an RCB fan.

An actor prepares
Saniya is the first artiste to arrive at the sets. The actor shows no sign of nervousness and seems quite elated to be playing the role. She mentions how she has never gotten to play a "modern heroine who would enter the scene in slow-motion". Her character Anjali, she adds, is outgoing and socially active. "She is a social media influencer,

Into the scene

Actors Rio Raj and Saniya Iyappan take us through the making of their upcoming rom-com *Maddy*

someone who is very close to how I am in real life." Rio, meanwhile, plays Sachin, a young man ignorant of how to add a dash of romance. "He is an extrovert, but he doesn't know how to talk to women," says Rio, adding that the film takes a peek into the modern dating app scene.

The team is about to shoot a scene in which an intense conflict arises between Sachin and Anjali in a hotel room, and later, a scene set against the backdrop of a wedding. "It's a crucial scene in which Anjali gets emotional because she really likes Sachin, but something he does comes as a shock to

her." Saniya had earlier performed the same scene during her audition; however, she wants to clarify a few things with the director. "Because, that time, they thought I went a notch above what was required."

Rio doesn't believe in doing special preparations on the morning of the shoot. "I absorb the script when we do the bound script reading. I would have gotten into the film's mood then. Before shooting each scene, I just revise the dialogue. I don't want to go too prepared."

When the camera is being set up, Karthikeyan says he would chat with the actors to figure out their mindset. "I have

to gauge their mood and energy levels and set it all right. By the time they are ready, we would set the frame and rehearse the staging of the scene with my assistants taking the actors' positions," he informs.

Lights, camera, action!
On the third floor of the resort, a room is adorned with warm indoor lights, a filler light that recreates the appeal of the golden hour, and other boom arms and reflectors that the cinematographer feels are necessary. The camera



Tinseltown dreams
Rio Raj, Karthikeyan BK and Saniya Iyappan on the sets of *Maddy*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

cranks up, silence fills the air, and Karthikeyan calls for action. A wide master shot of the whole scene is shot – a pan shows Saniya at the washroom sink, then Rio entering the room – but the take isn't approved. Something seems amiss. The camera trolley gets reassembled differently. "We are changing the shot composition because committing Saniya's character first seems to lessen the impact," informs Karthikeyan.

Meanwhile, Rio opines on an addition to Saniya's dialogue that proves necessary. The next take begins, but Saniya fumbles while uttering the new addition to the script. I smile at her, for this was precisely what she had said would be difficult. The actor, who hails from Kerala, strives to learn her Tamil dialogues by heart – that's the first thing she does when she wakes up. "For me, once I understand the dialogue, acting becomes easy. I always ask them a day before for my script and for an assistant director to send me voice notes of those lines. Because when I read a script, I won't understand the nuances."

And so you are even more impressed when she aces her next take. "I am getting used to such improvisations. It's hard for me to process the dialogue and act emotionally."

When the mid-shot of Rio is taken, the crew is stunned to see how seamlessly he expresses the emotion and wells up. "It was in the script. His eyes should fill with tears," informs Karthikeyan.

The scene ends at around 8.30pm. As I hit the bed after a long day, it dawns on me that the team would be shooting the pivotal wedding scene right now. No matter what time of the day it is, there's a film crew somewhere in your city, hoping to create magic with their cameras. The glitzy film industry, as we know it, is one thing; behind the illusion, it is also a great dream machine that, like any industry, runs on blood, sweat, and ambition.

Action call

Like to criticise movies? Now make one. How new reality show *Big Pitchure* works

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You have always judged movies. Now, make one.

This is what upcoming pan-India reality show, *Big Pitchure* aims to tell audiences. In a bid to make cinema more accessible, this show will not only pick actors, writers and directors from the audience but also make them key decision-makers of the storyline.

Big Pitchure, which will stream on JioHotstar in five languages, will make the audience the stakeholders of a film project. The show will have people auditioning for various segments in filmmaking through both online and offline means, and choose the best among them to work on a pan-India project.

Explains RAV of Gammien Sports and Entertainment, "Every Friday, years of hard work are reduced to a few stars in a review. Can the same people who criticise a work of art make that art work?"

After 15 weeks of 60-minute episodes, which will stream every Sunday, the winners

will come together to make a feature film which will cater to a pan-Indian audience.

He adds, "We want to bridge the gap between audience judgment and the reality of cinematic creation. The final movie, which will be a nationwide theatrical, will be a film made by the people and for the people."

Big Pitchure will be hosted across languages by Indrajith Sukumaran (Malayalam), Navdeep (Telugu), Vasishtha N Simha (Kannada), and Vijay Raaz (Hindi).

In Tamil, it will be hosted by popular actor Bharath. The actor, recently seen on the big screen in crime thriller *Kalidas 2*, is looking forward to what he describes as an "altogether new experience". "Acting and hosting are two very different things," he explains, "I am working on being more spontaneous, as that will add value to my hosting skills. Contributing to nurturing the next generation of film industry personnel feels special. While there are several opportunities today due to the advancement of social media, seeing yourself in a full-length feature is still a big high; I'm glad that the ultimate winners of this show will get to experience that."



Bharath, the Tamil host of reality show, *Big Pitchure*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Joining the *Kakee Circus*

Gauthami Nair, who was recently seen in a Tamil web series, chats about balancing her multiple pursuits

Actor speak
Gauthami Nair.
SPECIAL
ARRANGEMENT

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Gauthami Nair laughs when asked about the number of films she has been doing since 2022: one every year till 2024. That is three films in as many years.

Nothing last year, and now, in 2026, the Tamil web series *Kakee Circus*. "I am lucky that people remember me enough to give me that one project a year!"

She is happy about the feedback coming the way of the series. "The audience loved the character, related to Shaily [her character] and

understood what we have been trying to express."

Kakee Circus is a quirky comedy about a heist in a small town in Tamil Nadu; the action unravels around a thief. Directed by Ameen Barif, who co-wrote the script with Akash Chandramohan, it was initially intended as a feature film in Malayalam.

"Akash and I have been in touch for a while, regarding multiple projects," she says, "This was one of the projects we discussed. One day, Akash told me it would be a Tamil web series. I liked the story, the team's conviction... Ameen was animated about the narration and the quirky characters."

Gauthami, who made her debut in 2012 with *Second Show*, has been part of films such as *Diamond Necklace*, *Koothara*, *2018*, *Meri Awaz Suno* and *Kondal*. She has directed a film, *Vrittham*.

She was pursuing her education alongside, which she admits caused gaps in her acting career, something which she intends to rectify.

Back to acting
She plans to direct films too, but that is in the future. "I have not fully quenched my thirst for acting. As it is, people are waiting for excuses to say that I am not acting, I don't want to give them any more reasons," she says.

Once she completes her doctorate, films will be her focus. She will return to Psychology later once she has had her fill of films.

As she has not been part of the industry consistently, the changes in it are rather glaring, she feels. She states that it is easier to get a break today than it was more than a decade ago when she started.

"I was lucky to get projects, but it was difficult to be a newcomer those days. But today, social media is a space for people to express themselves, and getting a role is not as difficult as it used to be."

Kakee Circus is streaming on ZEE5

Amarakalam once again

Amarakalam, the 1999 Tamil movie starring superstar Ajith Kumar and his actor-wife Shalini, is all set to be re-released in theatres this Friday. The re-release marks the 26th wedding anniversary of Ajith and Shalini, who tied the knot on April 24, 2000. Karthick V of Sparrow Cinemas is re-releasing the film in 4K resolution. Directed by Saran, *Amarakalam* was Ajith's 25th film. Raghuvaran, Nassar, Ponnambalam and Radhika featured in supporting roles in the film, which had a chart-buster album by Bharadwaj. The film also holds a special place in the hearts of Ajith fans, as it was on the film's sets that Ajith and Shalini first met and fell in love. Notably, the news about the re-release of *Amarakalam* comes just after Ajith's car racing team, Ajith Kumar Racing, secured the second place at the reputed Circuit de Spa-Francorchamps in Belgium.



Cop act

The makers of *Jailer 2*, starring Rajinikanth and directed by Nelson, have announced that the highly-anticipated movie has been wrapped up. Bankrolled by Sun Pictures, the sequel to the 2023 blockbuster will have music from Anirudh Ravichander. Apart from Nelson and Rajinikanth, Vasanth Ravi and Jaffer Sadiq are seen in a recent picture posted by the makers. Kannada veteran star Shivarajkumar is also playing a prominent role in the movie. Meanwhile, Nelson is set to direct the project which marks the grand reunion of Tamil stars Kamal Haasan and Rajinikanth. The movie is bankrolled by Red Giant Movies.



Magic in the air

Can a man pass through a mirror? Can a lady float in the air? Treat your family to one such magical experience this summer. 'Jadugar' Mangal (Rambhai Bachubhai Chudasama) and his son Yuvraaj, magicians from Gujarat, are set to entertain Chennai audiences. Presented by the TVK Cultural Academy, this month-long residency promises a blend of traditional Indian street magic and modern illusions. The duo promises to change 30% of the show daily. The shows are on from April 24 to May 31 (only on Friday, Saturday and Sunday evenings). While Friday has a 7pm show, Saturdays and Sundays have 4pm and 7pm shows. @ Raja Annamalai Mandram, Broadway (opposite High Court). For tickets, call 9884152200 or log on to www.bookmyshow.com



A new universe

Film production banner Hombale Films has announced *Mahavatar Parshuraam*, the second installment in its acclaimed animated epic franchise, the Mahavatar Cinematic Universe. The film, which comes as a sequel to 2025's *Mahavatar Narasimha*, will release in theatres on December 2027. Ashwin Kumar, who directed *Mahavatar Narasimha*, returns to direct the sequel, as does music composer Sam CS. Notably, the Mahavatar Cinematic Universe is planned to have seven films, all based on the avatars of lord Vishnu.